

SEID 2364 – Assignment 1 Moral Machine Dataset: Ethical Response Patterns + Journal Entry 1

Part A – Moral Machine Dataset Analysis

The Moral Machine dataset is a large collection of ethical decisions gathered from people around the world through online scenarios involving autonomous vehicles. Participants were asked to choose between different outcomes in situations where harm could not be avoided. Most scenarios involved deciding which individuals would be saved or sacrificed in a crash situation. The dataset records human moral preferences rather than objective ethical truths.

The dataset represents responses from many participants across different countries, cultures, and backgrounds. This makes it useful for observing large-scale patterns in moral reasoning. However, some groups may still be underrepresented. People without internet access, older populations unfamiliar with online platforms, or individuals from less digitally connected regions may not appear equally in the data. Cultural differences may also affect how people interpret the scenarios.

One major pattern in the dataset is that many participants preferred saving a larger number of people over a smaller number. This suggests that many people use a utilitarian style of reasoning where reducing total harm is prioritized. Another pattern is that younger individuals were often prioritized over older individuals. This may suggest that participants valued future life potential or remaining lifespan. A third pattern was that humans were generally prioritized over animals, showing that participants often placed greater moral value on human life.

Although these patterns are interesting, the dataset has important limitations. It can show what groups of people preferred, but it cannot prove what is ethically correct. Large numbers of people agreeing on something does not automatically make it morally justified. Cultural bias may also affect the results because different societies hold different moral beliefs. Aggregated data may hide disagreement, minority perspectives, or deeper ethical conflicts.

The dataset should therefore be used carefully. Crowd moral data may help researchers understand public attitudes, but it should not be the only basis for policy or autonomous system design. Ethical decisions involving human lives require transparency, accountability, and critical analysis beyond majority opinion. If such data is used in real systems, safeguards should include expert review, cultural diversity, public oversight, and clear ethical guidelines.

Overall, the Moral Machine dataset is valuable for understanding how people think about ethical dilemmas, but it should not be treated as a final authority on morality. It is better understood as a descriptive tool that reveals human ethical tendencies rather than a system that determines what is universally right or wrong.

Part B – Journal Entry 1

Exact First Prompts from Class

1. "What is Ethics?" 2. "How do you currently rely on to decide whether an action is ethical?" 3. "How do you currently decide whether an action is right or wrong?"

Responses to the Core Questions

1. What is Ethics? Ethics is the study of how people should behave and make decisions in ways that affect others. It involves ideas about fairness, responsibility, harm, and what society considers morally acceptable.

2. How do you currently rely on to decide whether an action is ethical? I usually rely on personal values, social norms, and the possible consequences of an action. I also consider whether the action could harm someone physically, emotionally, or socially.

3. How do you currently decide whether an action is right or wrong? I decide based on whether the action causes unnecessary harm, violates fairness, or negatively affects other people. I also think about how I would feel if the same action was done to me.

Refined Ethical Framing Questions

Original Question: "What is Ethics?"

Refined Question: "How can ethical systems help evaluate actions and their consequences in society?"

This revised question is more analytical because it focuses on how ethics functions as a framework for evaluating decisions. It also moves beyond a simple definition and encourages deeper discussion about ethical reasoning.

Original Question: "How do you currently rely on to decide whether an action is ethical?"

Refined Question: "What principles, values, or consequences influence ethical decision-making?"

This version is clearer and more structured because it identifies the specific factors that shape ethical judgment. It also allows comparison between personal, cultural, and formal ethical systems.

Original Question: "How do you currently decide whether an action is right or wrong?"

Refined Question: "How should harm, fairness, and responsibility be balanced when evaluating actions?"

This revision improves the question by focusing on multiple ethical dimensions rather than personal opinion alone. It encourages more critical analysis of conflicting values and difficult decisions.